FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Their back stories tell you just how many boundaries and ceilings they each had to breach to get to the pinnacle of white-ball cricket. Shafali Verma disguised herself as a boy to play cricket in the rough-neck country of Rohtak, Haryana. Amanjot Kaur, a carpenter's daughter, first batted with a willow hand-crafted by her father from leftover wood. Deepti Sharma had to hone her skills alone at dawn in the shadow of the Taj Mahal, but now has her street named after her. Jemimah Rodrigues, a pastor's daughter, found her path in life when she watched Sachin Tendulkar from her Bandra balcony as an 11-year-old. Captain Harmanpreet Kaur, while on tour, makes video calls back to her family in Moga, Punjab, to hear the hymns from the local gurudwara. Together, with other teammates who each possess an enchanting life-story, they scripted a symphony of success like no other.

To say that India's historic win in the 2025 Women's Cricket World Cup sparked a wave of elation nationwide would be both true and an understatement. It was the culmination of a hard 51-year journey of heartbreaks and near-misses, since the time the Indian women's team was formed in 1974. Many are likening it to Kapil's Devils pulling off the World Cup victory in 1983. The parallels are all there: long, frustrating decades, even longer odds. Then a euphoric moment of triumph that seems to change everything, not just cricket. With this women's team, that feeling is sharper. The 52-run victory over South Africa is so much more than a sporting milestone. In a country still grappling with gender inequality, what it signals is a whole new era of empowerment.

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The sense of occasion was infectious. The 40,000 screaming supporters jampacked into DY Patil Stadium in Navi Mumbai were just the tip of the iceberg. Combined TV and digital viewership, already 60 million halfway through the tournament, peaked at 190 million for the final. The team didn't let them down. Here were young women looking destiny in the eye, not blinking, and plucking it out of the sky. Like Amanjot who dived after a fumble for the catch that swung the match. Or Shafali, still sporting the 'boy cut' her father gave her as a young girl, who smashed 87 off 78 balls, with seven fours and two sixes, and returned to bowl seven overs, taking two wickets with her 'golden arm'. Or wicket-keeper Richa Ghosh, whose whirlwind 34 off 24 balls was scored despite a hairline fracture. The veterans shone too. Smriti Mandhana, the 29-year-old star southpaw, averaged over 54 in the tournament, ensuring fightable totals for her team. Harmanpreet, now 36 and in the national side since 2009, has seen the heartbreak of the 2017 final when India lost by a whisker. But here she was, captaining with rare calmness, even pulling off a magical catch to give India the victory.

History was at hand, literally. Present at the stadium was the entire women's cricketing galaxy, from the first generation of Diana Edulji and Shanta Rangaswamy to the stars of the near past, like Mithali Raj and Jhulan Goswami, all partaking of the unbelievable scenes of jubilation and tears of joy. Together, they trace an epic odyssey where women's cricket was always given the short shrift and never got a fraction of the spotlight male superstars enjoyed. Mithali, who captained the 2017 World Cup team, writes for us about those times. Not too long ago, women got just Rs 1,000 as match fees. That has been changing. In 2022, the Indian board, then under Jay Shah, launched the Women's Premier League (WPL) and announced equal match fees for men and women: Rs 15 lakh for Tests, Rs 6 lakh for ODIs, Rs 3 lakh for T20s. Even here, the 2025 Cup set new benchmarks, with India's champions receiving a record prize money of $4.48 million (roughly Rs 40 crore), more than double from last time, besides a Rs 51 crore cash prize from the BCCI. The WPL, too, became a talent nursery like the IPL: young Shree Charani from Andhra Pradesh's Kadapa, who wove a web of spin around the best in the final, was fast-tracked into the team straight from the league.

Women stars have been a relative rarity in Indian sports, still making the transition from the sporadic individual brilliance of a P.T. Usha, a Sania Mirza, a Mary Kom or a P.V. Sindhu to those who show signs of a system being there, like the wrestlers. This changes that permanently. That's why the legendary Sunil Gavaskar, exulting with everyone else in the stands, calls the win "one of the greatest in the history of Indian cricket", gender no bar. Our cover story, by Deputy Editor Suhani Singh, catches the pulse of the moment as well as the depth of history, along with thumbnail sketches of the stars.

We hope no girl has to hear the lines Deepti heard in her childhood: "*Mat khilao Sharmaji, ladki hai.*" This victory is not just about cricket. It's about rewriting the rules of what's possible when talent meets opportunity, when grit meets recognition, and when a nation finally learns to celebrate its daughters with the same fervour it reserves for its sons. Call it a watershed moment. Call it long overdue. Either way, it's ours to cherish and build upon.

(Aroon Purie)